

The Nature and Role of Masculinity in the Modern World

Masculinity is not a fixed essence but a historical and cultural construct. As Connell observes, our modern notion of “masculinity” arose only in early-modern Europe alongside colonialism and capitalism: it is “built on the conception of individuality that developed in early-modern Europe with the growth of colonial empires and capitalist economic relations”^[1]. In other words, the gender polarities we take for granted are relatively recent. European culture before the eighteenth century did not even have a separate concept of masculinity distinct from femininity^[2]. Thus, the ideals of manhood we inherit were shaped as Europe expanded abroad. This essay examines how colonialism, imperialism, and militarization forged modern masculine ideals how global violence and state power inserted masculinity into politics and how in turn these forces produced exaggerations of masculinity.

Connell believes that masculinities are historical objects. Our contemporary ideals of manhood arose in the early modern period, not in some timeless past. In Europe’s sixteenth and seventeenth centuries, crises such as the Wars of Religion and the rise of the national states gave new prominence to war, and honor. Religious wars and professional armies helped establish a “patriarchal order...with the aid of the new power of the nation state”, tying masculinity to public power and violence. Around the same time, the Renaissance and Protestant Reformation shifted culture away from monastic asceticism toward a celebration of heterosexual marriage and individual agency. Connell notes that this “conception presupposes a belief in individual difference and personal agency”^[3], in other words, a modern idea of personhood that went hand-in-hand with empire. Capitalism and urban growth also reinforced new gender norms. Men increasingly defined themselves as economic actors, entrepreneurs, colonists, or soldiers and these roles carried masculine expectations. In Connell’s view, the word “masculinity” is a

product of this period. Connell thus reminds us that many traits we call “male” (strength, rationality, aggression) were not always gendered they became so alongside empire, capitalism, and modern science.

From these early developments, Connell argues, emerged the modern gender order: a global system in which men’s social positions and bodies became meaningfully organized as “masculine” or not. The five hundred year rise of European and North American world power has been deeply gendered. As Connell writes, “the historical processes that produced global society were, from the start, gendered”. Imperial conquest, missionary work, colonization, and the global expansion of capitalism carried particular gender norms worldwide. Conquerors encountered many societies and imposed their own masculine ideals; colonized peoples were racialized into hierarchies of manliness. In short, *globalization is gendered at its core*. Today we live in a “world gender order” that bears the imprint of these forces. According to Connell globalization created new arenas of gender relations beyond any single nation: transnational corporations, international diplomacy and United Nations bodies, global media, and markets all shape how masculinity is defined. These institutions are mostly run by men and propagate male centered norms, so they extend and reshape the masculine power structures that colonialism first set in motion. Thus, from a Connell’s perspective, modern masculinity cannot be understood apart from the history of empire, capitalism, and the rise of the national state.

Furthermore, Heather Streets examines a concrete example: British colonialism in India. She shows how imperial culture constructed “martial races” as a justification for empire. In this ideology, “some groups of men are biologically or culturally predisposed to the arts of war”. The British singled out, for example, Scottish Highlanders, Punjabi Sikhs, and Nepali Gurkhas as the empire’s ideal soldiers. As one commentator notes, in public discourse, these men “became

linked as the British Empire's fiercest" warriors ^[4]. In other words, by labeling them martial, the British elevated these colonized or peripheral men to the status of the empire's premier masculine heroes. According to Streets, this racialized myth served a double purpose: it allowed British officers to recruit loyal indigenous troops (whom they praised as exceptional men), while also defining all other subjects as inferior or effeminate. In effect, colonial rule wove race into masculinity. The narrative of the fierce "martial race" became an official cultural script a cultural narrative linking race, gender, and imperial power. It reinforced hierarchy and justified continued military control.

Connell's analysis complements this by emphasizing that every imperial contact brought together different gender orders. As globalization linked societies, local masculine norms mixed with the colonizer's norms, producing hybrid outcomes. In the colonial context, local elites often adopted the colonizer's masculine ideals to gain status but also developed resistance masculinities. For instance, the Indian Rebellion of 1857 was framed by British war propaganda as savage and anti-family a "crucible" in which notions of manhood were renegotiated. The British press portrayed Indian rebels as degenerate "fanatics" attacking women and children, which in turn inflamed English patriots. This incident shows how colonial narrative making about masculinity could manipulate public outrage.

Military institutions have been central to this history. Connell notes that the growth of national armies in early modern Europe forged new connections between masculinity, power, and patriotism. Soldiers and veterans became cultural exemplars of manliness, and the virtues they embodied to define the male ideal in many societies. The Bible, media, and schooling all began to celebrate the martial warrior image as the epitome of manhood. This militarization of masculinity intensified in modernity: the two World Wars and numerous colonial campaigns

reinforced the link between masculinity and state violence. Although Connell does not use the term hyper masculinity, her analysis implies it: the ideal “hegemonic masculinity” in wartime often emphasized almost superhuman aggression and stoicism. In Connell’s terms, hegemonic masculinity is the culturally exalted form that legitimates male dominance during wars, this took on a hyperbolic edge.

In the contemporary world, hyper masculinity can be defined as the exaggeration of stereotypical male traits (aggression, competitiveness, sexual conquest). This exaggeration often draws directly on the colonial military legacy. For example, modern action films and video games valorize soldiers as manly heroes. Political rhetoric in many countries still invokes hyper masculine imagery: leaders boast of being “strong as steel” or “born fighters,” and struggles are portrayed as masculine battles. Connell’s framework would interpret this as a continued dominance of the old martial ideal. The state and media, as institutions of power, perpetuate those narratives. On a social level, hyper masculinity can also be seen in phenomena like toxic competitive cultures and in the backlash against social change (where some men feel their traditional status is threatened, and respond by doubling down on aggression).

Crucially, cultural narratives about masculinity support and are supported by institutions. In Connell’s account, modern capitalism and statecraft are not gender-neutral. The transnational corporation, for example, is a “strongly masculinized” workplace ^[5]. Women are often kept out of top ranks, and senior leadership is coded masculine. International diplomacy and development agencies, too, have masculine cultures, albeit more mixed. Global media (news, movies, advertising) circulate masculine imagery worldwide: action heroes, male sports stars, and even male victims or “manly” survivors of disasters reinforce what “masculine” looks like. These narratives gain force from institutional backing. Militaries around the world modeled on Western

imperial armies recruit and train young men into a warrior culture; each uniformed soldier absorbs the myth that heroism and manhood are one. Colonial governments, as Streets shows, used stories of “savage” versus “martial” masculinity to legitimize rule. Even today, some postcolonial armies and police forces keep alive the labels of “martial races”, affecting how colonial history and masculinity intertwine in public memory.

These patterns persist: for instance, media coverage of conflict often emphasizes male action and valor. Advertisements might link products to rugged masculinity or adventure. Connell’s analysis of gender structure tells us that such cultural symbols are part of the masculine gender order as they reinforce men’s dominance by glorifying a certain image of manhood. Importantly, Connell argues that when hegemonic masculinity changes (through crises, cultural shifts, and new politics), the old “masculine rule” can be contested. We see this, for example, in debates over “toxic” male culture and in movements that encourage alternative masculinities. But the cultural narratives born of colonial and military history still have great power, often eclipsing other models.

In sum, the modern idea of masculinity is deeply tied to the historical forces of empire, capitalism, and war. Connell’s key insight is that masculinities are plural and historical not a single universal essence but different ideals that change with time and place. She shows that the “hegemonic” form of masculinity in any era is closely linked to the institutions of power at that time. As British colonialism illustrates, those institutions have long involved military force and racial hierarchy. Heather Streets’ study makes concrete how one empire fused race and virility into a global masculine myth. Today, we live with both the benefits and dangers of this legacy: many men still enjoy social privileges from the “patriarchal dividend,” but an excessive glorification of aggression and domination leads to the hyper masculinity that can fuel violence

and inequality. A critical perspective requires tracing these roots and imagining other ways of being male that do not depend on coercion or imperial power. Understanding the history from colonial settler warlords to “martial race” ideology helps us see that masculinity has always been a political project. In other words, the male role was invented not by nature, but by history and can be reinvented.

REFERENCES:-

1. **Connell, R. W. (n.d.). *The social organization of masculinity*. Retrieved May 1, 2025,**
from
https://www.academia.edu/43747837/The_Social_Organization_of_Masculinity_by_Rae_wyn_Connell#:~:text=on%20the%20conception%20of%20individuality,principle%2C%20does%20not%20have%20a
Connell explores masculinity as a social structure, paying attention to masculinities within hierarchies. She locates the institutional organization of the gendered structures, stressing power, class, and status politics in determining individuals who are assigned "real" manhood. This seminal book positions masculinity as a plural, historically situated thing.
2. **Connell, R. W. (n.d.). *The social organization of masculinity*. Retrieved May 1, 2025,**
from
https://www.academia.edu/43747837/The_Social_Organization_of_Masculinity_by_Rae_wyn_Connell#:~:text=on%20the%20conception%20of%20individuality,principle%2C%20does%20not%20have%20a
This recurrence underlines Connell's argument that hegemonic masculinity organizes institutions, from the workplace to the family, by idealizing certain male attributes (strength, rationality) at the expense of others. It provides a conceptual model for the analysis of how cultural common sense about manhood is constructed, reproduced, and challenged in social and economic orders.
3. **Connell, R. W. (n.d.). *The social organization of masculinity*. Retrieved May 2, 2025,**
from
https://www.academia.edu/43747837/The_Social_Organization_of_Masculinity_by_Rae_wyn_Connell#:~:text=on%20the%20conception%20of%20individuality,principle%2C%20does%20not%20have%20a
Connell's chapter traces how "masculinity" emerged alongside early modern state and capitalist formations, showing that traits we now gender as male strength, rationality, and aggression were historically aligned with the rise of professional armies, religious wars,

and individualist marriage norms. It situates hegemonic masculinity within the entwined processes of empire, capitalism, and modern science.

4. **Imperialism and War: Lecture Notes 5. (n.d.). Retrieved May 3, 2025,** from <https://www.studocu.com/en-us/document/fordham-university/war-and-imperialism-advanced-history-core/imperialism-and-war-lecture-notes-5/1099886#:~:text=o%20%E2%80%9CThe%20belief%20that%20some,little%20to%20do%20with%20race>

These lecture notes outline the “martial races” doctrine used by colonial powers to justify imperial recruitment and control. They explain how certain ethnic groups were racialized as innately warlike, legitimizing military hierarchies and reinforcing racial stereotypes. The summary highlights ideological strategies that underpinned colonial violence and governance.

5. **Connell, R. W. (n.d.). *Masculinities*. Retrieved May 4, 2025,** from https://www.academia.edu/44470472/Connell_Masculinities#:~:text=regions,ives%20and%20sexual

In this, Connell introduces the concepts of hegemonic, complicit, subordinate, and marginalized masculinities, showing how cultural and institutional contexts privilege certain male norms. Through historical and cross-regional examples, the book illuminates the social construction of manhood and remains a cornerstone for analyzing power, gender relations, and identity.

BIBLIOGRAPHY:-

1. Benjamin, W. (2025). On the concept of history. In N. Naqvi (Ed.), *what is modernity? CORE 102 Course Pack*.
2. Connell, R. W. (2005). *Masculinities*. University of California Press.
3. Streets, H. (2004). *Martial races: The military, race and masculinity in British imperial culture, 1857–1947*. Manchester University Press.